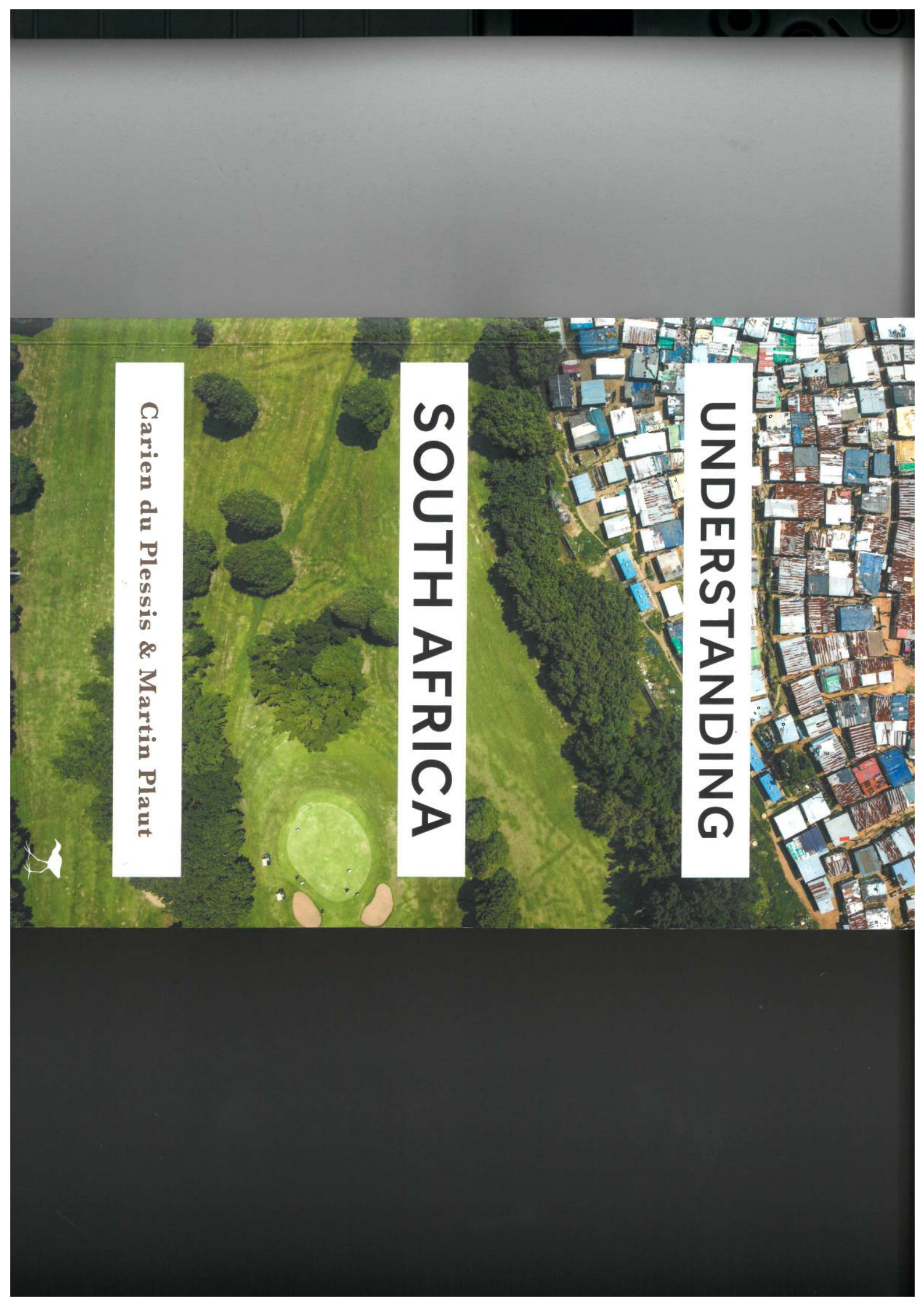




UNDERSTANDING

SOUTH AFRICA

Carien du Plessis & Martin Plaut



## CONTENTS

### *Abbreviations*

vii

|                                                              |     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| 1. Introduction: Extraordinary Country, Contrasting Lives    | 1   |
| 2. A Brief History                                           | 5   |
| 3. The African National Congress                             | 35  |
| 4. The Political Opposition                                  | 59  |
| 5. Corruption: The Legacy of Apartheid                       | 93  |
| 6. The Economy: Explaining the Failure to Thrive             | 111 |
| 7. Land and Agriculture: The Thorniest Topics                | 131 |
| 8. Education: The Weakest Link                               | 147 |
| 9. Justice and the Law                                       | 167 |
| 10. Civil Society: The Push from Outside                     | 187 |
| 11. Violent Politics in a Violent Society                    | 201 |
| 12. The Making of President Ramaphosa                        | 219 |
| 13. The 2019 Election Leaves the Country Stirred, not Shaken | 231 |

### *Notes*

247

### *Index*

301

First published in the United Kingdom in 2019 by

C. Hurst & Co. (Publishers) Ltd.,

41 Great Russell Street, London, WC1B 3PL

First published in southern Africa in 2020 by Jacana Media (Pty) Ltd

10 Orange Street

Sunnyside

Auckland Park 2092

South Africa

+2711 628 3200

www.jacana.co.za

© Martin Plaut and Carlen du Plessis, 2019

All rights reserved.

ISBN 978-1-4314-2987-5

Cover design by publicide

Cover photograph © Johnny Miller

Set in Junicode 11.5/15pt

Job no. 003666

Printed by  **novus print**, a Novus Holdings company

See a complete list of Jacana titles at [www.jacana.co.za](http://www.jacana.co.za)

## A BRIEF HISTORY

### *Approaching doom*

Driving north from Cape Town the flat top of Table Mountain gradually recedes in your rear-view mirror. Wheat fields and vineyards turn to scrub as the terrain becomes increasingly arid. The Cederberg Mountains—rock-strewn massifs of yellow, orange and sage green—rise around the road. Finally, after 155 kilometres, one arrives at Porterville, a nondescript town of some 9,000 people at the foot of the Olifants River Mountains. There is little to detain even an inquisitive visitor in the town, but in the mountains above Porterville is one of the most remarkable works of art in all of southern Africa.

Painted in red ochre on the walls of a rock shelter is a four-masted European galleon in full sail, with flags flying. Probably painted in the eighteenth century, it is the work of a member of the Khoisan.<sup>1</sup> The Khoisan were the original inhabitants of southern Africa: the region's 'first nations', once called 'Bushmen' or 'Hottentots'. For the artist who saw the vessel it must have seemed like something from outer space. The image made such an impression that, although Porterville is more than 100 kilo-



## UNDERSTANDING SOUTH AFRICA

metres inland, it had to be captured on the walls of the shelter. It was, in reality, a vision of impending doom.

Southern Africa has been inhabited for around 10,000 years, first by hunter-gatherers and then by people who cultivated crops and herded their animals—mostly sheep. Their legacy lies in the paintings and engravings which are found in almost every district in South Africa; there are at least 20,000 sites and over a million images.<sup>2</sup> Around 2,000 years ago other peoples arrived from central Africa. They were the Bantu-speaking peoples and—like most arriving settlers—they lived alongside, fought with, traded with and married the original inhabitants.<sup>3</sup> Gradually the Khoisan found themselves relegated to the southern fringes of the region and its arid interior.

### *White settlement*

By 1488, when Portuguese explorer Bartolomeu Dias rounded the Cape—the first to do so—most of the peoples of southern Africa lived in the interior. To the rest of the world they were of little interest, and so they remained until 1652 when the first permanent European settlement began. This was to be a refreshment station, and not a colony, on the way to the lucrative Dutch colonies in the East Indies which provided the spices sold at exorbitant prices on European markets. When the Dutch East India Company, which controlled this trade, decided to send Jan van Riebeeck to lead an expedition to Cape Town he was under strict instructions to establish a fort, a place to berth vessels and plant gardens for fresh produce—nothing more. The South African interior—from the Company's point of view—was an irrelevance. On his arrival van Riebeeck encountered the Khoisan. Soon he was planting a thick hedge of wild almonds in an attempt to keep them from the well-watered fields on which he planted the Company gardens.

## A BRIEF HISTORY

Just seven years after van Riebeeck arrived the first clash took place between the two communities, over crops and livestock. The Khoisan leaders explained their anger at the appropriation of increasing parcels of their land, as recorded in van Riebeeck's own journal in April 1660:

They asked if they would be allowed to do such a thing supposing they went to Holland, and they added: 'it would be of little consequence if you people stayed here at the fort, but you come right into the interior and select the best land for yourselves, without even asking whether we mind or whether it will cause us any inconvenience ...'<sup>4</sup>

A pattern had been established: expanding colonial settlement leading to war and trade between the settlers and the indigenous communities.

Gradually, supplemented by imported slaves from the Dutch colonies in the East, the settlement expanded. Some left the Company's employment and became 'free burghers'—citizen farmers. These Dutch farmers gradually intermarried with local peoples and with others—including French Huguenots—who arrived to escape religious persecution. If they were itinerant they were called 'Trek Boers', and later Afrikaners. Their actions had little impact on the rest of the world. As the historians Richard Elphick and Hermann Gillomee put it, 'Three hundred years ago the Cape Colony was a poor, underpopulated territory of interest to no one but its rulers, its inhabitants, its neighbours and a few inquisitive travellers.'<sup>5</sup>

The Bantu-speaking peoples, who had arrived centuries before the whites, split broadly into two groups: the Tswana and Sotho, who settled in the northern and central areas of what is today South Africa and Botswana, and the Nguni peoples of the Eastern Cape, Swaziland and KwaZulu-Natal, today known as the Zulu and Xhosa. The Drakensberg Mountains formed a rough division between these groups, although there was consid-

## UNDERSTANDING SOUTH AFRICA

erable exchange between them.<sup>6</sup> At first, whites—whether farmers, missionaries or traders—had little contact with these peoples. But contact was inevitable as the Cape Colony's frontier gradually expanded, with itinerant farmers moving away from Cape Town in search of grazing for their flocks.

Gillomee provides a graphic account of how this took place:

During the eighteenth century the line moved more than 800 km further as hunters, traders, raiders and, finally, cattle farmers pushed eastward into the interior. During the same period, along the southeastern coast, the limits of Xhosa settlement were slowly moving westward. In about 1770 the vanguard of white settlement reached the outlying Xhosa chiefdoms, and the so-called Eastern Frontier opened. Here European and black pastoralists displaced and finally subjugated the last of the eastern Khoikhoi ('Hottentot') clans. Here, too, began the process of interaction between white and black which has dominated South African history. For four decades trekboers and Xhosa, both aided at various times by Khoikhoi, jostled each other, neither succeeding in establishing supremacy, until in 1812 a combined colonist-Khoikhoi force under British military leadership finally pushed the Xhosa over the Fish River.<sup>7</sup>

There then followed a series of brutal wars between the whites and the Xhosa that continued, sporadically, for a century between 1779 and 1879. What had begun as border skirmishes ended with the conquest of the territory by the British.

If the eighteenth century had seen the gradual expansion of white settlement at the Cape, the nineteenth century was to see a transformation in the territory that became South Africa.

The first major event took place soon after the British seized the Cape in 1795, ending Dutch rule. In 1807 the British government outlawed the slave trade, but not slavery itself. This threatened the farming practices of the whites, many of whom relied on slave labour. Shiploads of slaves had been imported from India, Sri Lanka (then Ceylon), Indonesia, Madagascar and

## A BRIEF HISTORY

Mozambique—some 63,000 slaves in total.<sup>8</sup> Wealthy farmers owned as many as twenty slaves. Farmers who had bought slaves on credit faced ruin, and there was anger at British interference in local affairs. Despite this opposition, the movement for emancipation, driven in Britain by men such as William Wilberforce and his friends among the Cape missionaries, was unstoppable. In 1833, the British parliament banned slavery across the Empire. Dr John Phillips, the leading missionary at the Cape, went to London and mounted a vigorous campaign for black rights, supported by the most effective campaigning organisation of the time, the Anti-Slavery Society.<sup>9</sup>

As a result, a series of laws was passed guaranteeing the political rights of the African and Coloured peoples of the Cape.<sup>10</sup> These were strengthened by the Privy Council, which ruled on 15 January 1829 'that all Hottentots and other free persons of colour lawfully residing in the Colony, are, and shall be, in most full and ample manner, entitled to all and every, the rights, privileges and benefits of the law to which any other of His Majesty's subjects are, or can be, entitled'.<sup>11</sup> The equality of all people—black or white—appeared to be assured.

In 1836 the Cape's Legislative Council created municipal boards for the colony's towns and villages. The vote was given to any man as long as he had property worth £1,000, or paid a yearly rent of not less than £10 per annum. Any qualified man could stand for election.<sup>12</sup> From the very beginning, people of colour participated in these elections. The Cape had established a limited non-racial franchise. In Natal (proclaimed a British colony in 1843) there was a similar right, but it was so proscribed by regulations that very few Africans, Coloureds or Indians ever qualified for the vote. In the rest of South Africa the franchise was exclusively restricted to white men, although there was no property qualification.

The extension of political rights was deeply resented by the white farmers of the Cape, some of whom could trace their roots



## UNDERSTANDING SOUTH AFRICA

back to the first colonisation of the country in April 1652. Many were itinerant farmers who moved across the vast open spaces of the Cape. Their livelihoods were dependent on the availability of cheap labour. To them it appeared that the British were determined to undermine the Afrikaner way of life.<sup>13</sup> Starting in 1834 these farmers set out on one of the defining events of white history—the movement of 12,000 Afrikaners out of the Cape and over the Orange River, to escape London's grasp. It became known as the 'Great Trek'. The Afrikaners moved away from the Cape in the hope of leaving British dominance behind them. They carved out an independent existence, cultivating their farms and clashing with the African peoples in whose midst they had arrived. Britain, somewhat reluctantly, granted them independence in the South African Republic (or, more colloquially, the Transvaal) and the Orange Free State.<sup>14</sup>

The arrival of the trekkers was by no means the only blow that African communities experienced. Many of them had already been severely displaced and weakened by the *Mfecane* (meaning 'crushing' or 'scattering'), a series of events that are still controversial today. These conflicts convulsed southern Africa between 1815 and 1840. They involved the rise of the Zulu kingdom under their leader, Shaka. Using novel tactics and instilling discipline in young men grouped into 'age regiments', Shaka succeeded in dominating the region, brutally crushing those that failed to surrender.<sup>15</sup> The resulting instability forced the flight of vast numbers of people—perhaps as many as 1 million or even 2 million. Some, like the Ndebele, ended up in what is today Zimbabwe; others in Swaziland or Mozambique and even further afield. The Basotho, under Mosheshoe, clustered together in the mountain kingdom of Lesotho. Refugees from the *Mfecane* were forced into isiXhosa-speaking areas of the Cape. In the seventy years or so after 1760, the political face of the region north of the Orange (River) and east of the Kalahari was pro-

## A BRIEF HISTORY

foundly changed,' John Wright concludes.<sup>16</sup> Out of several hundred small, decentralised chiefdoms came large, centralised kingdoms, of which the Zulu in the East and the Ndebele in the West were the best known.

The Zulu nation soon also received a crushing blow. Conflict with the Boers had continued on and off ever since the murder of Piet Retief and his party during negotiations with the Zulu over land in February 1838. The British declared Natal a colony in 1843 and expanded their influence beyond the coast. In 1879 they attacked the Zulu, who were this time led by Cetshwayo. An initial Zulu victory at Isandlwana astonished the British, but they soon recovered and brought in reinforcements. Cetshwayo's army was decisively defeated at his capital of Ulundi on 4 July 1879. The Zulu kingdom was split into thirteen territories and divided among chiefs loyal to the British Crown.

### *Gold and diamonds*

Important as these events had been, they were eclipsed by the discovery of first diamonds and then gold, which transformed the region profoundly. There had long been an interest in commercial mining, and in 1866 diamonds were discovered around Kimberley. It was here that Cecil Rhodes, a mining magnate and passionate advocate of imperialism, made his fortune. African mines were controlled severely. From 1856 it had been a crime in the Cape to break a labour contract, and this measure was soon adopted by the Natal and the Boer republics.<sup>17</sup> On the diamond fields black labourers were forced to live in compounds, conditions which white workers refused to accept for themselves.<sup>18</sup> The outlines of what was to be formalised as apartheid many years hence were beginning to take shape.

Then, in 1884, gold was found in the Eastern Transvaal and on the Witwatersrand—the area around what is today the city of

## UNDERSTANDING SOUTH AFRICA

Johannesburg. White prospectors poured into South Africa from across the globe.<sup>19</sup> In the Transvaal the 'uitlanders', as the foreigners were known in Afrikaners, soon outnumbered the burghers, or citizens.<sup>20</sup> By the outbreak of the Anglo-Boer War in 1899 it was estimated that there were some 76,000 Boers in the Transvaal and around 225,000 'uitlanders'.<sup>21</sup> The Boer republics of the Orange Free State and the Transvaal resented this influx, but the development of an industrialised and commercial economy also tipped the scales decisively against the black societies of southern Africa.

The mines required vast quantities of labour. There was plenty of gold, but the mines were deep and the percentage of gold in each tonne of rock mined was low, so the wages had to be kept down if the operations were to be profitable.<sup>22</sup> Further restrictions followed controlling the movement of Africans—these became known as the 'pass laws'. In 1897 George Albu, chairman of the Association of Mines, explained to a government commission of inquiry that he proposed to reduce the cost of his labour by 'simply telling the boys [African labourers] that their wages are reduced'. Asked whether he believed that the men should be forced to leave the rural areas to work he replied: 'I think a kaffir should be compelled to work in order to earn a living.'<sup>23</sup>

These events transformed South Africa. Its heartland moved from the ports of Cape Town and Durban to the Transvaal and the Witwatersrand. Within ten years of its foundation, Johannesburg, as the centre of the gold industry, had a population of 102,000.<sup>24</sup> Mining, rather than agriculture, became the core of the economy.<sup>25</sup>

### *The rise of 'school people'*

Colonial expansion and the consequent destruction of African societies took place throughout the nineteenth century, but there

## A BRIEF HISTORY

was another side to the story. African peoples adapted and began to come to terms with the whites they found among their midst. They became market farmers, competing effectively with white farmers. Missionary schools were established, and taught the gospel and rudiments of education. Gradually a stratum of educated, prosperous Africans emerged.

By the 1860s, missionary education had given rise to a class of 'school people' who had 'emerged as a distinct stratum of society in the Eastern Cape and started to make their voices heard'.<sup>26</sup> Among these 'school people' were the young leaders of the future. Walter Rubusana, a future leader of the African National Congress (ANC), received his education at the Lovedale Missionary Institute in the Eastern Cape. Sol Plaatje, who chronicled the experience of Africans in the Siege of Mafeking during the Anglo-Boer War before helping to found the ANC in 1912, was taught by missionaries in the Northern Cape.<sup>27</sup> John Langalibalele Dube, the first president of the ANC, studied at Adams College near Durban.<sup>28</sup> In a few decades the missionaries had produced a class of well-educated young men who had the skills and the confidence to lead their people.

Britain granted the Cape Colony the power to govern its own internal affairs in 1872, ushering in a new political consciousness and the growth of political parties. African voters took advantage of this and in 1873 a group of 100 voters registered in the Queenstown district, accounting for over 10 per cent of the electorate in the constituency.<sup>29</sup> African voters were becoming a force to be reckoned with. By 1886 Africans made up 43 per cent of the vote in six constituencies of the Eastern Cape.<sup>30</sup> This was recognised—particularly by the defeated candidates, who attacked the missionaries for 'manipulating' the election by encouraging African voters and called for the Africans to be removed from the voters' roll.<sup>31</sup> It was a theme to which white racists were to return time and again in the years ahead.



## UNDERSTANDING SOUTH AFRICA

For the newly enfranchised, the ballot box was beginning to prove an effective means of making one's voice heard. This view was expressed by Isaac Wauchope, an interpreter at the Port Elizabeth magistrates' court:

Your cattle are gone, my countrymen!  
Go rescue them! Go rescue them!  
Leave the breechloader alone  
And turn to the pen.  
Take paper and ink,  
For that is your shield.  
Your rights are going!  
So pick up your pen.  
Load it, load it with ink.  
Sit on a chair.  
Repair not to Hoho [a mountain fortress],  
But fire with your pen.<sup>32</sup>

By the close of the nineteenth century the country had been utterly transformed. Most of the African peoples had been conquered, but a new wave of 'school people' were beginning to organise to improve their lot. The economy had taken off, with mining replacing agriculture as its central wealth generator. Cities had sprung up in the centre of the country, where none had existed before. Indians had arrived in Natal as indentured labourers to harvest its giant sugar plantations and to mine its coal. While the Cape and Natal were under British control, London was greedily eyeing the riches of the Boer republics of the Transvaal and the Orange Free State. It was the contest to win control over the gold and diamonds that was to plunge the British and the Boers back into their second—and far bloodier—conflict.

### *The Anglo-Boer War (1899–1902)*

Cecil Rhodes and other mining magnates had long chafed under Afrikaner rule. They argued that they were being scalped by the

## A BRIEF HISTORY

Transvaal. Living under its complex and truculent president, Paul Kruger, they complained that they were deprived of a right to citizenship, while being heavily taxed. Rhodes claimed that the industry could save £2,500,000 a year if the Transvaal had a sympathetic government.<sup>33</sup> Impatient with the British government, he plotted to overthrow Kruger by launching a raid from Bechuanaland (today Botswana) with troops from Rhodesia (today Zimbabwe). The attack, which became known as the 'Jameson Raid', took place between 29 December 1895 and 2 January 1896. Kruger easily thwarted the raid when a planned uprising in Johannesburg failed to materialise. The raid was a catastrophe for Rhodes and the British, but the issue of the Transvaal would not go away.

The Queen's subjects in the Transvaal petitioned her for protection. On 4 May 1899, Sir Alfred Milner, High Commissioner for Southern Africa, sent London an urgent dispatch. 'The case for intervention is overwhelming,' Milner wrote. 'The spectre of thousands of British subjects kept permanently in the position of helots, constantly chafing under undoubted grievances, and calling vainly to Her Majesty's Government for redress, does steadily undermine the influence and reputation of Great Britain and respect for the British Government within its own dominions.'<sup>34</sup> This position was summed up by the poet laureate, Alfred Austin:

There are girls in the gold-reef city,  
There are mothers and children too!  
And they cry, 'Hurry up! For pity!'  
So what can a brave man do?<sup>35</sup>

Relations between Pretoria and London went from bad to worse, but Britain was supremely confident. On the one side stood Britain and all its imperial possessions. On the other side stood the two Boer republics, whose total population was tiny by comparison.<sup>36</sup> Despite this, at the outbreak of the war the two Boer republics managed to field some 50,000 well-armed and



## UNDERSTANDING SOUTH AFRICA

well-provisioned men, while the British (who had not really prepared for the conflict) had barely 20,000 troops at their disposal.<sup>37</sup> The Afrikaners had used their gold to purchase fine German Mauser rifles and modern, rapid-firing artillery.<sup>38</sup> By comparison the British army was deficient in tactics, leadership, uniforms and manpower.<sup>39</sup> It was unprofessionally led, and lacked the means to organise its forces.

Within weeks the Boers had routed their enemies, driving deep into the British colonies of Natal and the Cape. But Britain overcame her initial hesitancy and began mobilising her forces, drawing on soldiers from Australia, Canada, New Zealand and India. Gradually the weight of numbers, together with fresh tactics, wore down the Boers. They lost the territory they had captured, and some Boers drifted away from the battlefield and returned to their farms. On 5 June 1900 Kruger's capital, Pretoria, fell. The Boer forces were close to disintegration and the conflict was all but at an end. On 30 May 1900 Milner had declared to a friend that the war was over: 'I have saved the British position in South Africa, and I have knocked the bottom out of "the great Afrikaner nation" forever and ever.'<sup>40</sup> He could hardly have been more wrong.

Deprived of the cities, the Boers adopted guerrilla tactics. Boer commandos fanned out across the open veld, attacking British lines of communication. In retaliation, and to deprive their fighters of supplies, the British burnt their farms to the ground. In the Orange Free State alone, 600 farms were destroyed within the first six months of 1900.<sup>41</sup> The scenes were heart-breaking. Captain L. March Phillips provided a moving description of what took place:

The worst moment is when you first come to the house. The people thought we had called for refreshments, and one of the women went to get milk. Then we had to tell them that we had come to burn the place down. I simply didn't know which way to look ... We can't

## A BRIEF HISTORY

exterminate the Dutch or seriously reduce their numbers. We can do enough to make hatred of England and thirst for revenge the first duty of every Dutchman, and we can't effectively reduce the numbers of the men who will carry that duty out. Of course it is not a question of the war only. It is a question of governing the country afterwards.<sup>42</sup>

Having destroyed their homes, the British consigned Boer women and children to concentration camps, in which they languished. Their African servants, imprisoned nearby, were even more harshly treated. The camps became a byword for oppression and thousands died of disease and malnutrition.<sup>43</sup> Under unrelenting pressure, Boer fighters became exhausted and dispirited. The rebels gradually drifted away from their commandos. Some went over to their British foes. By the end of the war 5,000 Boers had joined the British (more than a quarter of the Afrikaners then in the field) and Boer leaders feared that their forces might surrender *en masse*.<sup>44</sup>

The time had finally come to sue for peace. In March 1902 both sides agreed to further talks. Boer leaders gathered in the Transvaal town of Vereeniging to discuss their terms, among them Jan Christian Smuts. Once a bookish and sometimes sickly child, but later a lawyer and philosopher, he had been transformed by the war into a tough, resolute guerrilla commander.<sup>45</sup> Smuts had fought behind British lines, and was in the Northern Cape when negotiations began. He held a meeting with General Kitchener, the British military commander.<sup>46</sup> Kitchener, who had ruthlessly prosecuted the war, was by this stage convinced of the need to strike a deal with the Boers.<sup>47</sup> The meeting was a turning point, for it addressed the key issues that separated the two sides: among them the question of the treatment of Africans. Although the war had not been fought over this, it was the first issue that Smuts raised. The record in his notebook began: 'Natives to be disarmed and no franchise until after self-government.' At

## UNDERSTANDING SOUTH AFRICA

Smuts's insistence the British abandoned suggestions that Africans should be given the vote in the Transvaal and the Orange Free State. As Smuts's biographer noted wryly: 'Surrender was not all on the Boer side.'<sup>48</sup>

There were still Afrikaners who believed they should fight on to the 'bitter end', but the leadership, including generals Louis Botha and Smuts, felt the game was over. On 16 May 1902 Smuts made a passionate plea to the assembled Boers at Vereeniging:

We have still 18,000 men in the field, veterans, with whom you can do almost any work. We can thus push our cause, from a military point of view, still further. But we are not here as an army, but as a people ... We represent, not only ourselves, but also the thousands who are dead ... and the men and women who are dying by their thousands in the Concentration Camps of the enemy; we represent the blood and tears of an entire nation.<sup>49</sup>

On 31 May 1902, after much debate, the peace terms were finally put to the assembled Boer leaders. Of the sixty who were present all but six voted for the motion, but not all Boers accepted the terms, which required them to sign an oath of allegiance to Britain. The division of the Boers, between those who decided to come to terms with living under the British Empire and those who saw this as a betrayal, was to haunt Afrikaner politics for the rest of the century. While Botha and Smuts made their peace with London, others did not.

### *White South Africans make peace with Britain*

The war left South Africa terribly scarred. The losses among the Boer troops stood at over 7,000. Between 18,000 and 28,000 of white women and children died in the concentration camps, as did many thousands of Afrikaners, who had even poorer conditions. The exact number of Africans who died was not recorded.<sup>50</sup> Hardly a farm remained unscathed; their roofs were destroyed,

## A BRIEF HISTORY

their windows and doors were burnt for firewood and their livestock was butchered. In due course, £3 million was provided by the British to rebuild the country, but most went to those who surrendered early rather than those who held out to the end.

It was a bitter peace indeed, but the fate of the black population was more bitter still. The British had promised to safeguard their rights, but when the war ended London had other priorities, foremost among them a settlement with the Afrikaners. Afrikaners and Coloureds who attempted to assert their rights were forced off white farms they had taken during the war and were driven back to work, sometimes by British troops they had welcomed only months earlier as their liberators. It dawned on all concerned that the price of reconciliation between Briton and Boer would be paid by black people.

In 1906 the Transvaal was granted self-government, and the following year so too was the Orange Free State. White politicians began to discuss unity between the two Boer republics and the English-speaking Cape and Natal. A National Convention took place in Durban in October 1908, bringing together politicians from the four South African colonies as well as Rhodesia. The aim was to draw up a Union constitution. Africans petitioned London for a say, but this was not granted. The future of the country would be decided by whites alone, even though by 1909 there were 14,388 Coloured voters and 6,633 Africans in the Cape, making up 14.8 per cent of the electorate. In the end, the white politicians arrived at a compromise: men of colour would retain their votes in the Cape, but only white men would vote in the rest of the country.

It was this compromise—unsatisfactory as it was for most South Africans—that the white leaders took to London in June 1909 for ratification. A second delegation also made the journey. This delegation represented, for the very first time, a group of politicians of all races. Only Gandhi and the Indians remained



## UNDERSTANDING SOUTH AFRICA

aloof, sending their own delegation.<sup>51</sup> Led by the most liberal white politician of his day, William Schreiner, they included the brightest and best of their generation. The preacher and author Walter Rubusana, the newspaper editor John Tengo Jabavu and the educationalist John Langalibalele Dube were among them.

The official delegates, including Botha and Smuts, were royally treated. They were feted in parliament and had an audience with the king. The unofficial delegation led by Schreiner were politely received by government officials, but were promised nothing. They went to parliament, but only at the invitation of their supporters—including the newly-formed Labour Party, led by Keir Hardie. Hardie and his colleagues argued passionately for the Cape's non-racial vote to be extended to all South Africans, but with little success. In the end, Botha, Smuts and their colleagues got their way and the Union Constitution they had brought with them was endorsed by the Liberal government almost unchanged. Only on one point did the British hold firm: the right of people of colour to vote in the Cape would be enshrined in the Royal Instructions that accompanied the new Constitution. The king would effectively exercise a veto over any attempts to remove it, the House of Commons was told.<sup>52</sup>

This was not the only outcome of the long voyage to Britain. The formal negotiations over the Constitution had taken less than two days, but a second conference followed. 'The business that has brought these distinguished visitors to London is two-fold,' explained the *Daily Mail*, reporting the opening of the South African Conference at the Foreign Office.<sup>53</sup> 'They have to consider with the Government the final form of the Act of Union, and later to discuss with the Imperial and Colonial authorities the important question of imperial defence.' The defence conference brought together senior politicians from Australia, Canada, Newfoundland (still a separate territory), New Zealand and the four South African self-governing colonies.

## A BRIEF HISTORY

They met from 29 July until 19 August 1909 and finally agreed that the white dominions would share in Britain's burden of defending the Empire.<sup>54</sup>

The defence agreement came at a price.<sup>55</sup> On key issues like 'native rights' Britain promised it would not interfere in the domestic affairs of South Africa. It was an agreement that both sides would honour, to the intense frustration of black South Africans, whose petitions to the British were henceforth politely, but routinely, ignored. All such questions were henceforth to be settled in Pretoria, not in London.

The Africans on the Schreiner delegation, such as Rubusana, Dube and Jabavu, used their time in London to meet African students who were already living there. They discussed the situation back home, agreeing on the urgent need for a national organisation to represent all African opinion. ANC founding member Thomas Mapikele later recalled that 'the conversations which took place then had reference to the starting of the great African National Congress'.<sup>56</sup> On their return to South Africa the delegates were gradually reinforced by the students they had met in London. Pixley Seme was among this group of young, ambitious South Africans who had completed their legal studies abroad.<sup>57</sup>

This group of young, brilliant and well-educated men set about establishing themselves back home. They were determined to establish a united organisation to confront the emerging menace represented by white racism. Chapter Three will discuss how they came to found the African National Congress.

In 1913, on the eve of the First World War, the rights of Africans were severely undermined by a fresh law: the Natives Land Act. This reserved only 7 per cent of all land for Africans (later increased to 13 per cent). Although welcomed by some as a means of halting a land-grab by commercial farmers, it became one of the most notorious pieces of legislation in South Africa. The significance of the Land Act was immediately

## UNDERSTANDING SOUTH AFRICA

grasped by Sol Plaatje, the ANC's secretary general: 'Awakening on Friday morning, June 20, 1913, the South African native found himself, not actually a slave, but a pariah in the land of his birth.'<sup>58</sup> Plaatje toured the country, coming across families driven from the farms they had worked, travelling on the roads in the hope of finding new homes. There were suggestions of some form of strike action, but this received little support in the ANC and was voted down.

### *The erosion of black rights*

As the First World War loomed on the horizon, Afrikaners had to decide whether they should join their old enemy (Britain) in attacking their former allies during the Anglo-Boer War (Germany). Some Boer War generals, like Botha and Smuts, argued that they had made their peace with London; others were less forgiving. When the First World War erupted, Botha, by this time prime minister, immediately retelegraphed to London his willingness to take on the burden of his country's defence, allowing British troops to be redeployed to the war front. On 7 August 1914 the Colonial Secretary, Lord Harcourt, accepted Botha's offer and enquired whether South African forces could seize ports in the neighbouring German colony of South West Africa (today's Namibia).<sup>59</sup>

The South African cabinet met the same day to consider the request. According to London's wishes was not going to be easy. It took the prime minister three days of persuasion to achieve a unanimous vote in cabinet in favour of going to war—and even then, only by promising that the army would be composed solely of volunteers. Outside government the opposition was led by another Boer War general, James Barry Hertzog. He had refused to accept Botha's policy of reconciliation between English- and Afrikaners-speaking whites and had been excluded from the cabi-

## A BRIEF HISTORY

net. Then, in January 1914, he had broken with Botha to form the National Party.

When South Africa joined the British in August that year and Botha announced that forces would be sent into South West Africa, there was a mutiny. General Manie Maritz, a fiercely anti-British officer who commanded an area just south of the border, abandoned his post and led his troops to join the Germans—much to the amazement of the German commander. There was a full-scale rebellion in the Orange Free State and the Transvaal, with troops led by mutinous army officers. Some 13,000 Afrikaners took up arms against their own government. It took hard marches and sporadic fighting before the rebels conceded defeat.

By 1915, Botha was free to take command of the South West Africa campaign and lead his troops into the territory. After six months of hard fighting the Germans capitulated and Smuts led an attack on German forces in Tanganyika—now Tanzania. South African troops were dispatched to join the war in Europe. African volunteers on board the *SS Mendi* were sent to dig trenches, but were accidentally rammed off the Isle of Wight in February 1917. More than 600 men drowned.<sup>60</sup> On hearing of the tragedy, Botha led the House of Parliament in standing to pay tribute to their courage and sacrifice.

Botha died in 1919 and was succeeded by Smuts, who became one of the most senior politicians in the Imperial system, serving on the British cabinet in the First and then the Second World War. Smuts held the office of prime minister until he was ousted by Hertzog, his much more hard-line opponent, in June 1924. It was only in 1939 that Smuts managed to win the premiership once more—a post he held throughout the Second World War, before finally losing office to the National Party in 1948.

When the First World War was over, and the troops returned home, there were pressing issues to be faced. Afrikaners, many of them destitute, had flocked to the towns following the Anglo-



## UNDERSTANDING SOUTH AFRICA

Boer War. There they competed for jobs with African, Indian and Coloured labourers. Some joined unions to improve their lot. The interwar years saw fierce conflicts between labour and capital on the mines, leading to a full-scale uprising in Johannesburg in 1922. White miners fought for their rights, with one banner proclaiming: 'Workers of the World Unite, for a White South Africa.' The Smuts government crushed them ruthlessly, using troops, tanks, heavy artillery and aircraft.

The miners were defeated but two years later they had their revenge, inflicting a political defeat on Smuts. In 1924, a coalition led by Hertzog won the election, backed by the union's political representatives in the Labour Party. Henceforth the rights of whites would predominate in employment, as they did in politics. Legislation was introduced which strengthened the position of whites by enshrining differential pay and job protection. Hertzog introduced a 'civilized labour' policy in 1924, reserving categories of work on everything from the mines to the railways for whites. This was a bitter blow for the black population. Historian Phil Bonner sums up their plight: 'This left teaching and preaching as virtually the only avenues of white-collar employment open to educated Africans.'<sup>61</sup>

The political rights of Africans, limited though they were, were also under attack. In 1936, after a decade of agitating for the change, Hertzog managed to end the rights of African men to vote in the Cape. On 6 April, he persuaded the South African parliament—to the loud cheers of the white MPs—to abolish the Cape franchise.<sup>62</sup> For the first time since 1836, no African in any part of South Africa had the vote. Africans were instead presented with a limited form of parliamentary representation through special white parliamentarians. Political rights, cherished and protected for a century, were extinguished. British assurances that their rights would be protected by the king had proved worthless.

## A BRIEF HISTORY

By the late 1930s the shadow of war was looming over the world again. Would South Africa join Britain's defence once more? For Smuts there was no question, but Hertzog (who headed a coalition government) argued that the country should remain neutral towards Nazi Germany. It was an argument Smuts won. Hertzog resigned in September 1939, and Smuts once again became prime minister. South African troops fought, with distinction, in Ethiopia, the Western Desert and Italy. Some Afrikaners saw this as a betrayal: an alliance with the old adversary. The bitter legacy of the Anglo-Boer War still lingered. A neo-fascist movement, the Ossewabrandwag, was formed with a mission of resisting the British Empire, Jews and capitalists. Among its members were young men who would go on to become leaders of the country: B. J. Vorster (1966–78) and P. W. Botha (1978–89).<sup>63</sup>

### *Apartheid*

South Africans, black as well as white, participated in the Second World War. In total 334,000 joined up, including some 211,000 whites, 77,000 Africans and 46,000 Coloureds and Indians. Just over 11,000 lost their lives. As in the previous world war, the majority of whites who served were English-speaking. The black troops hoped, once more, that their loyalty would be rewarded, but once more they were disappointed.

When the war ended, the scene was set for a political transformation. Afrikaner nationalism, which had been on the rise for half a century, came to fruition. Afrikaners had taken measures to strengthen their positions. Some were economic—such as a range of mutual organisations that dealt with everything from insurance to burial societies. Others were directly political, including the formation of a secret society—the Broederbond (Brotherhood)—which co-ordinated strategy behind the scenes.